Ruling Ideas

A 20-minute team game on Marx. Earn tokens, take power, rewrite the rules, then see if anyone can stop you. Full rules are on page 2; the trivia is on the Host Sheet and the website.

Your three jobs

Host: runs the website (or reads the Host Sheet) and counts "3, 2, 1."

Banker (plays "the State"): holds all the tokens at the start, pays teams, and enforces whatever rule the Ruling Class picks.

Historian: judges close answers and explains what each round means.

The four teams

Team	Who you are	Your power (once per game)
Team 1 Factory Workers	The modern working class, packed into factories and cities by big industry. *(Communist Manifesto)*	**Union:** Pick another team (not the Ruling Class) to answer with you on one sheet. If you're right, both teams get 2 tokens.
Team 2 Guild Artisans	Medieval craftsmen and shopkeepers, squeezed out by big industry. *(German Ideology and Manifesto)*	**Roll Back the Wheel:** Ignore the Ruling Class's rule for one question, or skip paying the tax.
Team 3 Pin Makers	Adam Smith's ten workers, each doing one small step of making a pin. *(Wealth of Nations)*	**Division of Labour:** Collect 3 tokens instead of 1.
Team 4 Bedouin	Ibn Khaldun's desert tribe, held together by group feeling. *(Muqaddimah)*	**Asabiyyah:** One member of your team may pass.

Whoever becomes the Ruling Class plays the bourgeoisie, and its power switches off until it loses power. The other three keep their identities.

The game at a glance

Round	What happens	What it teaches
1. WORK 4 min	Questions 1–6. The team with the most tokens becomes the Ruling Class.	*Smith, Ibn Khaldun and Marx agree more than you'd expect, and the quotes prove it.*
2. RULE 4 min	The Ruling Class picks a Rule Card and finishes "This rule is good for everyone because…" Then questions 7–11 under the new rule.	*"The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas." Every ruling class says its interest is everyone's.*
3. WAGES 4 min	The Ruling Class can't answer the Hard Questions. Other teams undercut each other for the job; the winner answers, but the 3-token reward goes to the Ruling Class.	*Estranged labour: you do the work and someone else owns the result. Competition between workers pushes wages down.*
4. REVOLUTION OR CONQUEST 4 min	The Ruling Class may bribe one team. Then either every other team unites for a Revolution, or one team tries a Conquest alone.	*Marx says revolution ends class rule. Ibn Khaldun says conquest just swaps the rulers.*
DEBRIEF 3 min	The Historian shows "What you just played," then asks one closing question.	*Every move in the game was an argument from the readings.*

The Rules

Read this once before class. The Banker and Host should know rules 1–8 by heart.

Before you start

1. The Banker starts with all 80 tokens: 20 in each team's color.
2. Make 4 teams. Each team gets its Identity Card and 3 tokens in its own color from the Banker. The Banker keeps the other 68.
3. Each team needs scrap paper and a pen. Put the prize (candy) where everyone can see it.

Tokens

4. Whenever the Banker pays a team, it pays in that team's color. If a color runs out, it pays in any color.
5. When teams pay each other (wages, tax, the bribe), they can hand over any tokens they hold.
6. Tokens decide who rules and pay for wages and bribes. Who gets the prize depends on how Round 4 ends.

Answering questions

7. The Host reads a question. Teams get 20 seconds, then everyone holds up their answer on "3, 2, 1."
8. Every team that is right gets 1 token from the Banker. The Historian rules on close calls.

Team powers

9. Each team's power works once per game. Say it out loud at the moment shown on your Identity Card.
10. A team's power switches off while it is the Ruling Class.

Round 1: Work

11. Play questions 1–6. Then the team with the most tokens becomes the Ruling Class and takes the placard. If teams tie, play a tiebreaker: closest guess wins.

Round 2: Rule

12. The Ruling Class picks one Rule Card, reads it out, and finishes the sentence "This rule is good for everyone because…" The rule stays in force for the rest of the game, and the Banker enforces it.
13. Play questions 7–11. All four teams can answer, including the Ruling Class.

Round 3: Wages

14. The Host reads a Hard Question. The Ruling Class may not answer it.
15. The other teams compete for the job. The Host opens at a wage of 3 tokens and teams call out lower wages (2, 1, 0). The lowest offer wins; if two teams offer the same wage, the first to call it wins.
16. The winning team has 30 seconds to answer. The Ruling Class pays it the wage whether or not the answer is right. If the answer is right, the Banker pays 3 tokens to the Ruling Class. Play two Hard Questions.

Round 4: Revolution or Conquest

17. The Ruling Class may offer the Bribe card and 2 of its tokens to one team. A team that accepts keeps the tokens, cannot join a revolution or a conquest, and shares the prize if the Ruling Class keeps power.
18. A revolution happens only if every team except the Ruling Class agrees to join. Together they answer one Revolution Prompt, one sentence per team, and the Historian judges. If they succeed, the placard is torn up and everyone, including the old Ruling Class, shares the prize. If they fail, the Ruling Class keeps power and the prize.
19. If any team refuses to join, there is no revolution, but one team may try a Conquest (the first to call it). Every member names a different thing the bourgeoisie created or destroyed. If they succeed, they become the new Ruling Class and take the prize. If they fail, the Ruling Class keeps power and the prize.
20. If nobody tries anything, the Ruling Class keeps the prize.

Special cases

21. If the Ruling Class can't afford a wage, it goes bankrupt and the placard passes to the team with the most tokens.
22. Under the We Judge rule, the Ruling Class judges answers in Rounds 2 and 3. The Historian always judges Round 4.

Host Sheet

Read each question aloud, give 20 seconds, then count "3, 2, 1." The same questions are on the website.

Round 1: Work

1. Who said it? "It is not from the benevolence of the butcher, the brewer, or the baker, that we expect our dinner, but from their regard to their own interest." **A)** Marx and Engels **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: B) Adam Smith (Wealth of Nations, Book I) *Why it matters: The Manifesto describes the same thing as "naked self-interest" and "callous cash payment." Same fact, opposite verdict.*

2. Who said it? The bourgeoisie "has accomplished wonders far surpassing Egyptian pyramids, Roman aqueducts, and Gothic cathedrals." **A)** Marx and Engels **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: A) Marx and Engels (Manifesto, Section I) *Why it matters: Marx admires how productive capitalism is. The German Ideology says communism needs that wealth, or want is "merely made general."*

3. Who said it? Differences between peoples come from "the different ways in which they make their living." **A)** Marx and Engels **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: C) Ibn Khaldun (Muqaddimah, Chapter 2) *Why it matters: How people make a living shapes who they are. Ibn Khaldun said it more than 450 years before The German Ideology.*

4. Who said it? Doing a few simple tasks all day can make a worker "as stupid and ignorant as it is possible for a human creature to become." **A)** Marx and Engels **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: B) Adam Smith (Wealth of Nations, Book V) *Why it matters: Smith worried about this too. His fix is public schooling. Marx's fix is ending the division of labour.*

5. Multiple choice In Smith's pin factory, about how many pins can ten workers make in a day by splitting up the job? **A)** About 480 **B)** About 4,800 **C)** Upwards of 48,000

Answer: C) Upwards of 48,000 *Why it matters: One worker alone could hardly make 20. Dividing the work multiplies output, which Marx accepts. His question is who ends up owning the pins.*

6. Fill in the blanks Thesis XI: "The philosophers have only _____ the world, in various ways; the point, however, is to _____ it."

Answer: interpreted; change *Why it matters: The most famous line in the Theses, and the theme of this game: next round, someone gets to change the rules.*

Round 2: Rule (under the new rule)

7. Fill in the blanks The Manifesto's first line: "The history of all hitherto existing society is the history of _____ _____."

Answer: class struggles *Why it matters: Engels later added a footnote: he meant written history. Before that, he thought, came village communities without classes.*

8. Fill in the blanks Thesis VI: the human essence "in its reality … is the ensemble of the _____ _____."

Answer: social relations *Why it matters: No fixed human nature: you are your relationships. That's why a team's power switches off when it rules. Its position matters more than its identity.*

9. Multiple choice Feuerbach treated this tree as plain "nature," but The German Ideology points out that trade brought it to Europe only a few centuries ago. Which tree? **A)** Oak **B)** Cherry **C)** Pine

Answer: B) Cherry *Why it matters: Even the "nature" around us is shaped by history and trade.*

10. Multiple choice The Manifesto says the executive of the modern state is a committee for managing the common affairs of… **A)** the whole people **B)** the whole bourgeoisie **C)** the working class

Answer: B) the whole bourgeoisie *Why it matters: That's why our Banker plays the State: it enforces whatever the Ruling Class decides.*

11. Multiple choice In communist society, says The German Ideology, you could hunt in the morning, fish in the afternoon, rear cattle in the evening, and _____ after dinner. **A)** sleep **B)** criticise **C)** pray

Answer: B) criticise *Why it matters: Nobody is stuck being "a hunter" or "a critic" for life once the division of labour is gone.*

Host Sheet (continued)

Tiebreakers (closest guess wins)

T1. In what year was The German Ideology first published? Closest guess wins.

Answer: 1932 *Why it matters: Marx and Engels left the manuscript to "the gnawing criticism of the mice."*

T2. According to The German Ideology, how many vagabonds did Henry VIII of England have hanged? Closest guess wins.

Answer: 72,000 *Why it matters: Peasants pushed off the land became vagabonds before factories could absorb them.*

Round 3: Wages (Hard Questions, 30 seconds each)

Open the wage at 3 and let teams undercut each other. The Ruling Class may not answer. Use H1 and H2; H3 and H4 are spares.

H1. "Estranged Labour" says the worker is estranged in four ways. Name any two.

Answer: From the product of their labour; from the act of working; from their species-being (human nature); from other people.

H2. The Manifesto says the bourgeoisie gets out of economic crises in two ways. Name both.

Answer: Destroying a mass of productive forces; conquering new markets and exploiting old ones more thoroughly. Both set up bigger crises later.

H3. The German Ideology traces forms of ownership through history. Name the first two, in order.

Answer: Tribal ownership, then ancient communal and State ownership (as in Rome).

H4. Thesis III says "it is essential to educate the _____ himself." Fill it in and say why.

Answer: Educator. People change their circumstances, not only the other way round, so no group can stand above society as its teacher.

Round 4: Revolution prompts (pick one)

A good answer has the right idea plus a real example. The Historian judges.

P1. Explain Thesis XI ("interpret" vs. "change") using an example from student life.

Answer: A good answer separates describing a problem from acting on it, for example analysing why campus jobs pay badly versus organising to change it. Bonus for Thesis II: truth is proved in practice.

P2. Smith says people have a natural "propensity to truck, barter, and exchange." How would Thesis VI answer him?

Answer: There is no fixed nature inside each person; the human essence is "the ensemble of the social relations." Smith is mistaking a habit of commercial society for human nature.

Round 4: Conquest challenge

Every member names one different thing the Manifesto says the bourgeoisie created or destroyed. No repeats.

Answer: Accept any of these. **Created:** the world market, factories, railways, steamships, electric telegraphs, big cities, world literature, the proletariat, crises of overproduction. **Destroyed:** the guilds, feudal ties, old national industries, "Chinese walls," the family's "sentimental veil," the halo around doctors, lawyers, priests and poets.

Bonus Questions

Use these if you have extra time, need a replacement, or want a longer Round 1 or 2.

B1. Who said it? Employers are “always and every where in a sort of tacit, but constant and uniform combination” to keep wages down. **A)** Marx and Engels **B)** Adam Smith **C)** Ibn Khaldun

Answer: B) Adam Smith (Wealth of Nations, Book I) *Why it matters: Smith already sees the conflict between masters and workers that the Manifesto builds on.*

B2. True or false Ibn Khaldun thought city luxury makes a ruling group stronger with every generation. **A)** True **B)** False

Answer: B) False *Why it matters: Luxury weakens group feeling, so dynasties usually decline within a few generations and a tougher group takes over.*

B3. Multiple choice Ibn Khaldun’s word for the group feeling that lets a people conquer and rule is… **A)** hadara **B)** asabiyyah **C)** umran

Answer: B) asabiyyah *Why it matters: Hadara is settled city life and umran is civilisation. Asabiyyah is what the Bedouin team’s power is named after.*

B4. Multiple choice The German Ideology says ideology shows people and their circumstances upside down, as in a… **A)** mirror **B)** camera obscura **C)** telescope

Answer: B) camera obscura *Why it matters: Ideas look like they come first, but they are really flipped images of material life.*

B5. Fill in the blank Estranged Labour: “The worker becomes all the poorer the more _____ he produces.”

Answer: wealth *Why it matters: Compare Smith’s pin factory: more output, but not for the person making it.*

B6. Multiple choice The Manifesto says cheap prices are the “heavy artillery” the bourgeoisie uses to batter down all _____ walls. **A)** Roman **B)** Chinese **C)** city

Answer: B) Chinese *Why it matters: Trade, not armies, pulls every nation into the world market.*

B7. Fill in the blank Thesis X: “The standpoint of the old materialism is ‘civil’ society; the standpoint of the new is _____ society, or socialised humanity.”

Answer: human *Why it matters: Marx moves from isolated individuals in a market to people as members of society.*

Historian Sheet

Read one short line after each round, then use the table and a closing question for the debrief.

After each round

After Round 1: “Smith, Ibn Khaldun and Marx all think how we make a living shapes everything else. They disagree about what to do with that fact.”

After Round 2: “The Ruling Class just claimed its rule was good for everyone. Marx says every ruling class does this, and the State, our Banker, enforced it.”

After Round 3: “One team did the work and another got the tokens. That’s estranged labour. And you undercut each other on price, which is exactly how the Manifesto says wages fall.”

If revolution won: “You could only win together, the Manifesto’s “ever-expanding union of the workers.” And nobody replaced the Ruling Class. That’s Marx’s big claim: this revolution ends class rule itself.”

If conquest won: “New rulers, same rules. That’s Ibn Khaldun’s cycle: a united group takes power, gets comfortable, and is replaced by the next one.”

If ruling Class survived: “The bribe or the split did its job. The German Ideology says the ruling class lets a few people rise, but only by becoming part of it.”

What you just played (show this in the debrief)

What happened in the game	What it shows	Where it’s from
The leader wrote the rules	The ruling class’s ideas become everyone’s ideas	German Ideology, p. 172
The “good for everyone” speech	Every class dresses up its interest as the common interest	German Ideology, p. 174
The Banker enforced it	The state as “a committee” for the ruling class	Manifesto, p. 475
Teams undercut each other	Competition between workers pushes wages down	Manifesto, p. 479
The worker team didn’t get the 3	Estranged labour: the product belongs to someone else	Estranged Labour, pp. 71–78
Your power switched off when you ruled	Position matters more than identity	Thesis VI
The bribe split the teams	Workers’ unity is “continually being upset” by competition	Manifesto, p. 481
Only united teams could revolt	The “ever-expanding union of the workers”	Manifesto, p. 481
Conquest swapped the rulers	Ibn Khaldun’s cycle vs. Marx’s end of classes	Muqaddimah vs. Manifesto

Closing question (pick the one that matches how it ended)

Revolution won: Marx says this ends classes for good. Ibn Khaldun would expect new rulers within a few generations. Who’s right?

Conquest won: Was that the end of the cycle or just one turn of it? Can class struggle explain everything Ibn Khaldun explains?

Ruling Class survived: Thesis II says truth is proved in practice. By that test, how has the Manifesto held up?

RULING CLASS

You are the bourgeoisie now. Your team power is switched off.

"The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas."

— The German Ideology

fold here

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You are the bourgeoisie now. Your team power is switched off.

"The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas."

— The German Ideology

IDENTITY CARDS — cut out and give one to each team at the start

TEAM 1: FACTORY WORKERS

From the Communist Manifesto

The modern working class, packed into factories and cities by big industry.

Your power: Union

When: Rounds 1–2, before a question

Pick another team (not the Ruling Class) to answer with you on one sheet. If you're right, both teams get 2 tokens.

The Manifesto says the real fruit of workers' battles is "the ever-expanding union of the workers."

Once per game. Switches off while you are the Ruling Class.

TEAM 2: GUILD ARTISANS

From the German Ideology and Manifesto

Medieval craftsmen and shopkeepers, squeezed out by big industry.

Your power: Roll Back the Wheel

When: Any round, before the Host reads a question

Ignore the Ruling Class's rule for one question, or skip paying the tax.

The Manifesto says the lower middle class fights big business only to save itself: "they try to roll back the wheel of history."

Once per game. Switches off while you are the Ruling Class.

TEAM 3: PIN MAKERS

From the Wealth of Nations

Adam Smith's ten workers, each doing one small step of making a pin.

Your power: Division of Labour

When: Any round, after a right answer

Collect 3 tokens instead of 1.

Smith says ten workers who split up the job can make upwards of 48,000 pins a day. Marx agrees it's productive, but asks who ends up owning the pins.

Once per game. Switches off while you are the Ruling Class.

TEAM 4: BEDOUIN

From the Muqaddimah

Ibn Khaldun's desert tribe, held together by group feeling.

Your power: Asabiyyah

When: Round 4, during a Conquest

One member of your team may pass.

Ibn Khaldun says desert peoples have the strongest group feeling, which is why they conquer cities, until city luxury softens them too.

Once per game. Switches off while you are the Ruling Class.

RULE: DOUBLE PAY

Our right answers earn 2 tokens.

Everyone else still earns 1.

Say: "This rule is good for everyone because…"

RULE: TAX

Every other team pays us 1 token right now.

The Banker collects it for us.

Say: "This rule is good for everyone because…"

RULE: WE JUDGE

We decide if other teams' answers count.

Applies in Rounds 2 and 3. The Banker backs us up.

Say: "This rule is good for everyone because…"

THE BRIBE

Ruling Class only, at the start of Round 4.

Give this card and 2 tokens to one team.

If they take it, they can't revolt or conquer, and they share the prize if you keep power.

You can rise, but only by joining the rulers.

REVOLUTION

Every team except the Ruling Class must join.

Answer one prompt together, one sentence per team.

Win: the placard is torn up and everyone shares the prize.

Marx: end class rule for good

CONQUEST

One team goes it alone.

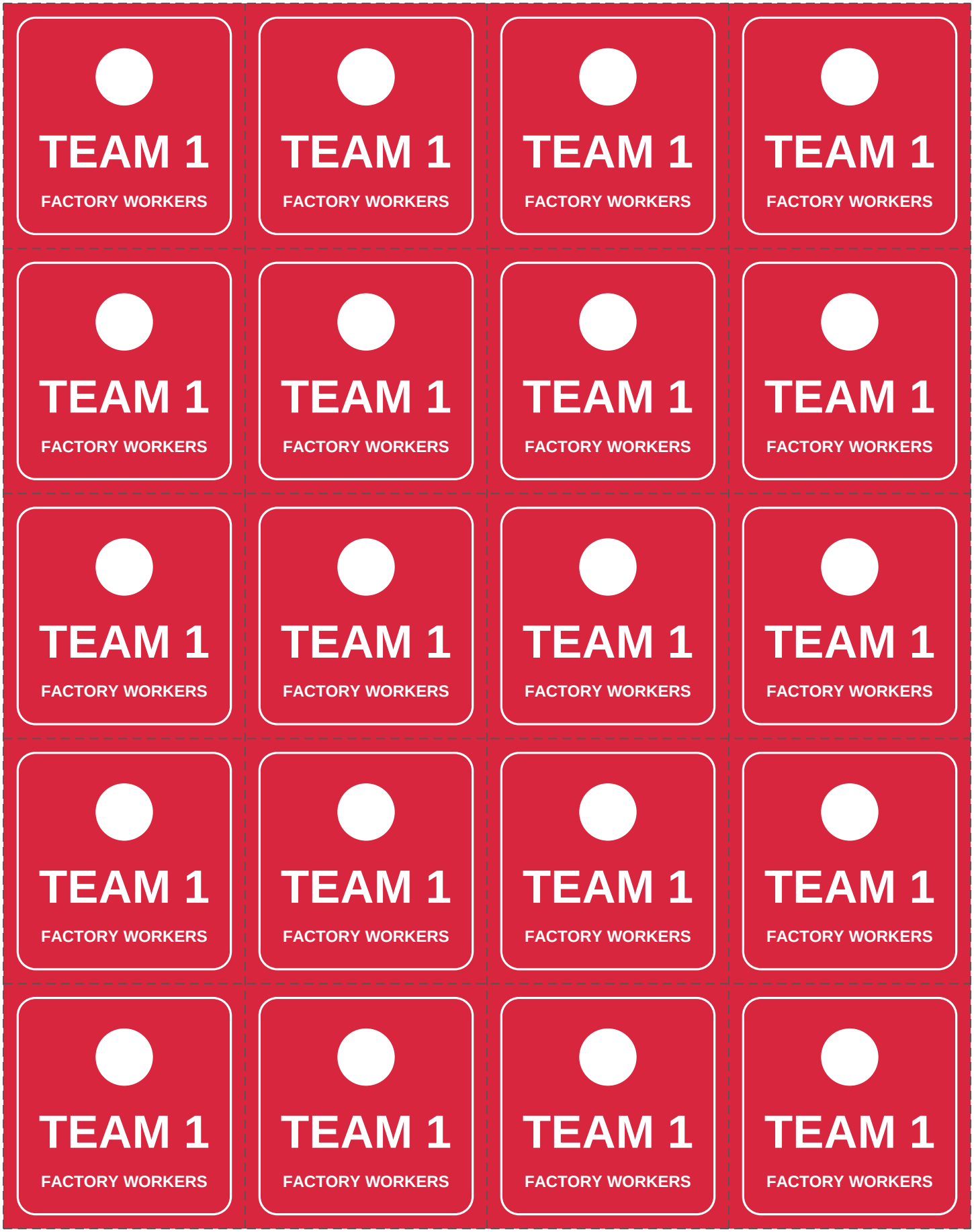
Every member names a different thing the bourgeoisie created or destroyed.

Win: you become the new Ruling Class and take the prize.

Ibn Khaldun: new rulers, same cycle

TEAM 1 TOKENS: FACTORY WORKERS

20 tokens · cut along the dashed lines



TEAM 2 TOKENS: GUILD ARTISANS

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TEAM 3 TOKENS: PIN MAKERS

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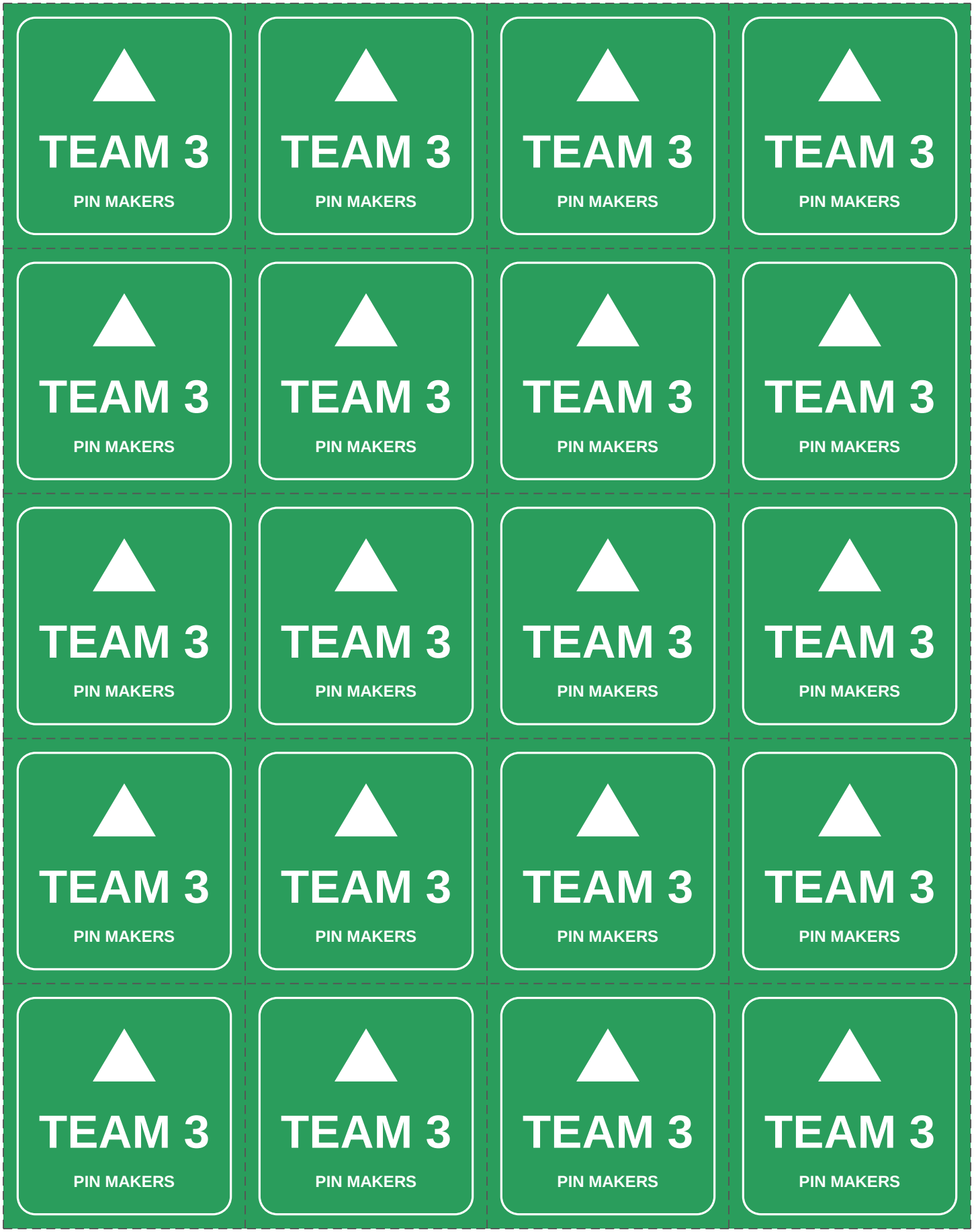

TEAM 4 TOKENS: BEDOUIN

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